

*The Emergence
of Latin America
in the Nineteenth Century*

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government. The main exception was Paraguay, which somehow survived until the 1840s without anything that could seriously be called a written constitution. Even Mexico and Brazil, which started out as monarchies—Mexico for about two years, Brazil for most of the century—were constitutional monarchies, in which the crowned ruler shared power with an elected parliament and other institutions. In all cases, the first Latin American constitutions incorporated some kind of separation of powers and something ostensibly comparable to the U.S. Bill of Rights or (more likely) the French Revolutionary Declaration of the Rights of Man.

The new governments did not constitute full-fledged democracies, however, even on paper, despite the fact that most of their leaders spoke loosely of the institutions adopted as "democratic." With rare exceptions, the right to vote was limited to free men (obviously never the unfree or women) who enjoyed a minimum amount of income or property or occupational status, in terms that normally excluded all but five to ten percent or some other quite limited number of male adults. (Admittedly, this was more than voted at the time in such an enlightened nation as France or in Great Britain before the passage of the Reform Bill of 1832.) In certain cases, illiterates—perhaps amounting to ninety percent of the Latin American population, a majority overlapping with but not exactly the same as those excluded from suffrage on socioeconomic grounds—were also denied the vote, though often as not the enforcement of the literacy test was held in abeyance. In the Gran Colombian constitution of 1821, for example, the literacy test was set to go into effect only twenty years later. The reason for this curious suspended sentence against illiterates was that it seemed unfair to deny the vote to anyone who was unable to read merely because the wicked Spanish oppressors had failed to provide sufficient schools; but after twenty years of freedom, presumably, anyone who truly made the effort would know how to read. In such expectations, the Colombian founding fathers were wildly overoptimistic.

The new nations placed still more stringent limits on who might be elected, and it need hardly be added that these restrictions as well as those on suffrage did nothing but give legal sanction to a pattern of limited participation in the political

nation. The cultivation of close relations with Great Britain, as the dominant political and military power of the Western world and also chief rival of the United States for trade and influence in Latin America, was in fact a constant in Bolívar's policy. Britain, though, was interested in commercial, not political, understandings, and the United States, even as it accepted the invitation to Panama, made clear that it did not want entangling alliances with its immediate neighbors any more than with Europe. After all, the Monroe Doctrine itself had been a unilateral statement of policy, and for many years any overtures for its conversion into a multilateral instrument were brusquely rejected by Washington. Since the Latin American nations also proved unable to cement a lasting alliance among themselves, each was left to fend strictly for itself—for better or for worse.

How Latin America Was Ruled: What Changed and What Did Not

Though privileged segments of the Latin American population had never lacked influence on the colonial administration and its policies, the final authority had always been external to Latin America itself. With independence, the ultimate power of decision making moved across the Atlantic, from Madrid or Lisbon to the new American nations, and the decision makers were no longer constrained by imperial considerations. In each capital they acted in the light of interests which might not be those of the population as a whole but were still those of locally dominant groups. No longer would trade with Spain or Portugal be legally favored, and much less would the treasury in Mexico City ship subsidies to that in Madrid. Neither would it continue subsidizing other parts of Spanish America, as it had often done before. (As a matter of fact, there was no money in it to pay subsidies with.) And the peninsular bureaucrats who, for reasons of paternalism or higher imperial interest, had occasionally intervened, say, to curb creole despoiling of Indian communal lands would no longer be able to do so.

The Indians themselves would have little more say in the new government than in the old, even though all or most countries adopted an outwardly representative, constitutional frame of

process that was largely preordained by the sharp cultural and socioeconomic differences existing among elements of the population. Nevertheless, to have any representative institutions at all was an abrupt change from the previous regime, where only municipal governments (and not all of them) were of elective origin. Now at least a select minority would be voting in elections—and voting was a form of political participation even in those instances when the elections served only to ratify some fait accompli—while the number of those being elected was not inconsiderable. Quite apart from the popular election of republicans, chief executives, a single royal legislator had given way since independence to collective bodies of national congressmen who themselves were liable to be replaced by newly elected members every few years. In countries that opted for a federal type of internal organization, there were additional elections held for state or provincial governors and assemblies.

Increased opportunities for government service were not limited to elective positions but existed elsewhere, perhaps most obviously in the military. Although armed forces had not usually been large even in the wars of independence (Bolívar never took even as many as ten thousand men into battle with him), the military still could not wither away when peace returned, and they were at least more numerous than those stationed in Latin America in the colonial era. Quite apart from the hypothetical danger of Spanish reconquest or other threats from overseas, there were often boundary or similar disputes with neighboring countries, not to mention the need for military forces in the lack of a professional police to help maintain internal order. Order could no longer be maintained through the instinctive obedience automatically inspired by a legitimate monarch of the traditional house. Moreover, the military institution even more than civil government branches offered avenues of upward advancement for the less privileged social strata. Here perhaps the classic example is Venezuela's José Antonio Páez. A functionally illiterate ranch hand in trouble with the law when the independence movement began, Páez proved to be a gifted leader of the *llaneros*, cowboys of the Orinoco River plains, and played a critical role in winning them over to the patriot side. By the time the struggle ended, he held the highest military rank, had ac-

quired vast landholdings (of originally loyalist ownership for the most part), and was also acquiring the rudiments of an education. Politically, even before Bolívar's death in 1830, Páez had become the dominant figure of independent Venezuela.

The pattern that Páez epitomized was often repeated in the postindependence years. Members of the traditional upper class generally held the top positions in the armed forces as elsewhere, but not enough of them felt called to a military vocation to fill all those available. Particularly in times of civil warfare, when forces expanded rapidly, there was room for tough, able, and often unscrupulous fighters to rise up through the ranks, and like Páez they might then parlay military success into political power and economic wealth. What usually came last, if at all, was acceptance as social equals by those who had been born into the upper strata—but their children would gain acceptance in any case. The fact remains that the armed forces were a shade more democratic in social makeup than other key institutions, and in this respect they clearly illustrate the increase of opportunities in public life that came about with independence.

The opportunities for upward mobility through the military were enhanced by the mere fact that political conditions in early independent Latin America were notoriously unstable. Social and economic conditions, it can be argued, were probably too stable, and the numerous "revolutions" for which Latin America became famous seldom involved many combatants; sometimes they did not even involve combat but rather shows of force and behind-the-scenes intrigue. Yet in Mexico, for example, during a period of almost thirty years only one president succeeded in serving out his entire term. As Argentine historian Tulio Halperín-Donghi has aptly put it, in nineteenth-century Latin America to lose an election was not the most common way for a party in power to go out of power.⁶ It was even somewhat exceptional. And, if casualties were generally few—all nineteenth-century Latin American revolutions together came nowhere near to equaling the death toll of the one U.S. Civil War—they did represent a net loss of human resources. Economic costs were appreciable too, including not just the expenses incurred in waging or defending against insurrections but also the reduced growth resulting from even temporary interruption of produc-

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tive activities and from the climate of uncertainty that inhibited investment and innovation.

One other thing that changed with the coming of independence, then, was the state of public order, which for Latin America as a whole visibly deteriorated, although there were wide differences in this matter among countries. Moreover, when political disturbances were brought under control or simply avoided, sometimes the successful formula involved blatant violation of constitutional procedures. One quite prevalent phenomenon was that of *caudillismo*, whereby a strongman, or *caudillo*, most often of military origin, came to exercise power regionally or nationally through his ascendancy over a band of personal followers, the use of various kinds of patronage to forge ties of clientelism with the surrounding population, and, where necessary, the use of brute force as well. The caudillo, if in command of the national government, might or might not be a full-fledged "dictator," but one can at least be sure that he did not feel strictly bound to observe all legal technicalities. In the political life of the new nations one could easily find still other unseemly practices, such as rigged elections and the casual usurpation of prerogatives of one branch of government by another, most often by the executive at the expense of congress or the courts. None of these practices was uniquely Latin American, none was universal, but they did seem all too characteristic of Latin American political behavior following independence.

The explanation most frequently encountered for the apparent gap between constitutional theory and practice (or, as some would have it, between the written and the unwritten constitutions of Latin America) is a supposed lack of prior experience in self-government. The Spanish and Portuguese colonies, unlike the English, had no trace of legal autonomy. They had no representative institutions except at the municipal level, and their higher officials were mostly sent from Europe rather than being natives of the colonies. As a result, so goes the argument, Latin Americans were quite unprepared to take over the management of their own affairs. It must be noted, however, that the great majority of public servants before independence *were* recruited locally. The very same postal clerks and corrupt customs officials were on hand (still with their hands out for bribes) to serve the

new republics as had served the colonial masters. Hence, only at the top levels was experience in governmental operations literally lacking, and even there it is likely that a greater problem was the general unfamiliarity of the *type* of institutions adopted, ostensibly popular in origin and subject to constitutional limitations as distinct from the patriarchal absolutism of the old regime.

In effect, the highest authority in the land was no longer that benevolent father figure, the king, his rule hallowed by religious teachings and civil tradition, but a written document that was hard for either governors or governed to take as seriously as the king's command was taken in the days of old. The importance of this factor becomes evident when one stops to consider that Spain and Portugal, the former mother countries, in the nineteenth century went through exactly the same kind of political upheavals as their ex-colonies—coups and civil wars, caudillos and dictatorships. In their case, it was hardly for lack of prior experience in governing themselves, but having lost their American empires they were now engaged in an effort to substitute a new form of constitutional monarchy for the previous absolute version. This was less drastic than the introduction of republican government but produced many of the same contradictions between the institutions adopted and habits of behavior built up over past centuries, or between those institutions and the cultural idiosyncrasy of the Iberian peoples. In the latter connection, an influential school of opinion maintains that such traits as an exaggerated sense of personal honor and the Catholic tendency to see truth as one and indivisible were incompatible with the values of a liberal political system, which required thoroughgoing respect for individual rights and sociocultural pluralism.

Any contradiction between political habits and cultural traditions on one hand and liberal institutions on the other was compounded in the mother countries by the fact that both Spain and Portugal had active minorities that still upheld absolute monarchy and did not accept constitutional government even in theory, much less in practice. This was not so in Latin America, where military dictators either denied that they were dictators or insisted, sincerely or not, that their dictatorship was a temporary expedient to deal with a national emergency after which normal political processes would be restored. At some times and in some

places, though, it seemed that dictatorship was really more "normal" than its opposite. And if doctrinaire absolutists were lacking, there was no lack of other issues on which peaceful compromise was either difficult or impossible to effect.

The Questions to Fight Over

One such issue was the status of the Roman Catholic church, which in the colonial period had a religious monopoly through the formal exclusion of other sects, a close alliance with the state, a fuero that exempted the clergy from the jurisdiction of the ordinary courts, and a vast amount of property and other wealth. The position of the church had already been adversely affected by some of the imperial reforms of the late colonial period, and it was further weakened by the wars of independence, in which it lost property as well as suffering some decline in numbers of clergy, most critically at the higher levels where Spanish-born priests had been disproportionately represented and often ended up in voluntary or involuntary exile. Even worse for the church, however, was the spread of anticlericalism, which did not challenge fundamental Catholic beliefs but did seek to diminish the role in society of the institutional church and of the clergy who administered it.

Anticlericalism resulted in part from secularizing tendencies in thought and culture that had been making headway since the eighteenth century as a reflection of the European Enlightenment and increased rapidly in scope once independence removed most of the previous legal barriers to their penetration from abroad. To some extent it resulted also from the desire of new creole and mestizo ruling groups to enlarge their own intellectual and socioeconomic spheres of activity at the church's expense. Abolishing the Inquisition had meant only that the holding of religiously heretical ideas was no longer in itself a punishable offense; to spread them by word of mouth or printing press or to hold worship services in accordance with them were different matters. After independence, however, the demand for full religious toleration was heard with increasing frequency. So were demands to end the fuero as contrary to the notion of equal rights

before the law, proposals for confiscation and sale of church property, and much more along the same line.

A related issue concerned the *patronato*, or system of civil patronage over the church, whereby traditionally the state in Spanish (as also in Portuguese) America, in return for promoting the spread of Roman Catholicism, had received from the papacy itself the right to control ecclesiastical appointments and in general the purely administrative aspects of the church. With the monarchs to whom this privilege had been given now out of the picture, the *patronato* should logically have ended, but the new governments insisted on retaining it as an essential attribute of sovereignty, and initially they found the warmest support for this claim among anticlerical spokesmen, whose hope was to use the *patronato* to dampen the inevitable clerical opposition to the reforms they had in mind. Both over the *patronato* as such and over those other reform proposals, controversy arose in one country after another. The fact that it reflected opposing attitudes toward religious faith and practice, than which no one force in Latin American society was more pervasive and deeply felt, ensured that there would be no easy solutions.

The religious question was also destined to become the primary litmus test for differentiating "liberals" from "conservatives" in nineteenth-century Latin America's political conflicts. These conflicts often revolved around rivalries of personalistic caudillos, but in Latin America, as elsewhere, personal and factional squabbles could exist perfectly well alongside or in combination with real differences of policy and program. At times, opposing viewpoints on national issues might then be expressed through formal Liberal and Conservative parties. But even where that was not the case, it was often possible to distinguish contrasting approaches or states of mind to which the same terms could be loosely applied, without the initial capital letters.

It is true that in political matters the differences between liberals and conservatives (with or without capital letters) were mainly of tactics and degree. Not only did absolutism no longer have defenders, but monarchy was an issue only in Brazil or, intermittently, in a few places like Mexico. And virtually everyone who took active part in the political process gave at least lip

service to the goal of representative, constitutional government, which was an essentially liberal objective. Hence, political conservatives were little more than moderate liberals, men who might be more inclined than their mainstream liberal counterparts to filter the expression of popular will through a system of indirect elections or to enlarge executive prerogatives. They were also less disposed than most liberals to look to the United States as model and more inclined, if borrowing laws and institutions, to adapt them from European constitutional monarchies. But there was also an evident tension within liberalism itself between the drive to expand individual liberty and a desire to use the power of the state to root out traditional abuses and humble any corporate groups that threatened individual liberty. (Liberal support for maintaining the patronato was just one example of the resulting inconsistencies.) In any case, political differences were by and large more of detail than of substance. The same was true in economic questions, where free-enterprise capitalism was generally accepted as the ideal, and disagreements concerned the relative haste with which colonial survivals that conflicted with the economic freedom of the individual—human slavery to the official limitation of interest rates—ought to be liquidated. On economic issues, moreover, considerations of sheer personal and group interest almost always took precedence over ideological consistency.

This left the church question as the one issue on which the distinction between liberals and conservatives was most clear-cut. Conservatives did not oppose all change in this area; neither did most of the clergy themselves. However, they valued the church not only for its spiritual consolations but also as a critically important underpinning of the social order. As the Mexican Conservative Lucas Alamán expressed it, "The first thing is to conserve the Catholic religion, because we believe in it, and because even if we did not consider it divine, we consider it to be the only common bond which unites all Mexicans, when all the rest [such as the monarchy] have been broken."⁷ Alamán and those of like mind in other countries shed no tears for the Inquisition, but they were otherwise inclined to move slowly and cautiously in trimming away the power and privileges of the church, lest they diminish its usefulness for purposes of social control. They also

quickly discovered that religion was the most effective single cause with which to stir the popular masses into action on their side, with the parish priest often serving as conservative ward boss in elections and even as recruiting officer in times of revolution.

Although there was a liberal minority within the clergy itself, the clergy as a whole was overwhelmingly conservative, if only for reasons of self-defense. For the rest, while it may be possible to say that merchants or landowners or professional men were predominantly either liberal or conservative in a given country at a given time, it is not possible to generalize about the political alignment of groups other than the clergy in Latin America as a whole. The exceptions are just too numerous. Moreover, outside the Middle and upper sectors of the population, most Latin Americans were simply indifferent to the political struggles taking place—if they were even aware that they were happening. Only in a few countries, of which Colombia and Uruguay are the best examples, did permanent political parties succeed in getting the masses to identify emotionally and instinctively with one or another of them; and even in such cases, when civil war broke out the average countryman was less interested in who won than in avoiding military service himself and keeping his domestic animals and valuables (if any) well hidden from either government or revolutionary foragers. Neither was it a common occurrence, though it did happen, for political leaders to appeal for popular support by espousing policies geared to the specific interests of rural or urban working-class groups. More often those leaders, generally representing rival portions of the same dominant class, were content to enlist the followers they needed by personal patronage or some form of compulsion.

A problem that cut across both political and class lines was that of regional or sectional rivalries. These had their roots in social, cultural, and ethnic differences and differences of economic interest from one place to another that were aggravated by the broken topography of much of Latin America. They antedated independence but had for the most part been kept just beneath the surface during the colonial regime. With the greater fragility of postindependence public order, these rivalries now welled to the surface with frequent destabilizing effect. In the large coun-

tries, which had more and larger distinct regions, sectionalism often found expression in demands for federalism as a type of constitutional organization. The latter entailed something like the U.S. model in which states or provinces that retained effective control over local affairs jointly established certain "federal" authorities to treat matters of general interest. Those who called instead for concentration of power in the hands of the central or national government viewed federalism as a dangerous source of governmental weakness and attributed the widespread infatuation with it to slavish imitation of an inappropriate foreign model. In reality, though, while federalists might copy some of the outward forms of the U.S. Constitution, they were not federalists for having read Hamilton and Madison. They embraced federalism because they felt their own needs were different from those of the people in the next mountain valley and were sure they could handle them better than a congress or bureaucracy in the remote national capital.

Statistically speaking, there was a slightly greater probability that federalists would be liberals and centralists would be conservatives, but, as will be seen, this was no hard and fast rule. At most, there was an inherent logical compatibility between federalism and the liberal concept of limiting government lest it trample on individual rights. Indeed, the only rule that admits no exception is that federalists, whenever they actually got the national government in their hands, were inclined to interpret its proper sphere of action a little more broadly than while they were languishing in opposition. For that matter, regionalism did not have to express itself in federalist guise; it could also take the form of mere refusal to heed the demands of central authority or of support for a regional caudillo as he climbed to national supremacy.

Regional rivalries, like religion, generated strong feelings and thus contributed to the intensity of political conflict. They generated especially strong feelings when the regions of a country were separated not just by distance and life-style but by clearly perceived differences of economic interest. But that is only one of the ways in which the economic and social structure contributed to the weakness of the political. A general state of economic underdevelopment limited the resources at the disposition of the

state for either good or ill, and the colonial legacy of pronounced social stratification, only partly offset by such phenomena as the upward mobility of plebeian military leaders, did not help the consolidation of anything remotely resembling democratic pluralism. Before examining some national case studies, therefore, it is time to look at the economic and social scene of newly independent Latin America in its own right.